

Academic Writing

- You are:
 - Engaging on an imaginary conversation with the potential reader
- Academic writing is all about **making arguments, based on claims**, which are **substantiated with evidence**
- Building an argument and making claims is the very essence of academic writing.
- Take up a position, and be able to justify and defend that choice

A step-by-step guide to a Reading journal

– Setting up a journal

- Buy a book or create a file on your computer
- Read the text (either at once, or in chunks)

NOT to remember verbatim

To understand what is going on in the text

- WRITE in your journal (book/computer file):
Write a **complete reference** at the top
 - What does this article remind me of? Why?
 - What does it agree with/disagree with? Why?
 - What really interests me about this?
 - How does it fit with my research interest/topic/question?

ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY

- A list of citations to books, articles, and documents
 - A brief (usually about 150 words) descriptive and evaluative paragraph
- Purpose:
 - Builds a record of your reading
 - Inform the reader of the relevance, accuracy, and quality of the sources cited
 - Each entry is a reflection on the text
 - **NOT** a summary or copied text in verbatim

ANNOTATIONS VS. ABSTRACTS

- **Abstracts** are the purely descriptive summaries
- Often found at the beginning of the article
- **Annotations** are:
 - Descriptive and critical
 - Expose the author's point of view
 - Clarity and appropriateness of expression, and authority

The Process

- First, locate and record citations to:
 - Books
 - Periodicals, and
 - Documents that may contain useful information and ideas on your topic
- Cite using the appropriate style
- Write a concise annotation/sentence that summarizes the central theme and scope of the reading
 - (a) evaluate the authority/background of the author,
 - (b) comment on the intended audience
 - (c) compare or contrast this work with another you have cited, or
 - (d) explain how this work illuminates your topic

An Example:

(The following example uses the **APA format** for the journal citation)

Waite, L. J., Goldschneider, F. K., & Witsberger, C. (1986). Nonfamily living and the erosion of traditional family orientations among young adults. *American Sociological Review*, 51 (4), 541-554.

The authors, researchers at the Rand Corporation and Brown University, use data from the National Longitudinal Surveys of Young Women and Young Men to test their hypothesis that nonfamily living by young adults alters their attitudes, values, plans, and expectations, moving them away from their belief in traditional sex roles. They find their hypothesis strongly supported in young females, while the effects were fewer in studies of young males. Increasing the time away from parents before marrying increased individualism, self-sufficiency, and changes in attitudes about families. In contrast, an earlier study by Williams cited below shows no significant gender differences in sex role attitudes as a result of nonfamily living.